

The Fourteen-Year Hitch

The IOA and the sports ministry have a very small window of opportunity before the opportunists return

■ By Sharda Ugra

K.P.S. Gill is a fortunate man. You may not have thought so seeing him emerge from the meeting where he had been effectively sacked. He left without the expected quivering moustache or bristling outrage, looking all aglum, like he'd drawn a bad hand at the blackjack tables in Las Vegas.

But until that day, Gill had been given a free hand for 14 years to do exactly what he wanted. Omissions, commissions (of all kinds), catastrophic failure, inconsistent selections, dubious book-keeping—Gill had built himself quite a hall of infamy. It needed the most literal, incontrovertible proof of decay within the Indian Hockey Federation (IHF) to bring his unsavoury reign to an end. It took a video of the IHF secretary K. Jothikumaran reaching across a table to firmly grasp a wad of cash. Look ma, greased palms.

There is a certain satisfaction at seeing a dictator fall, specially one as ruthless and unrepentant as Gill. This is not the end of the autocrat though; there is a very good chance that he will abandon his once-loyal, now-disgraced aide Jothi and go to court to scramble for his throne again.

What the Indian Olympic Association (IOA), which moved swiftly to suspend the IHF and now controls the sport, the hockey community and the Sports Ministry have is a very small window of opportunity before the opportunists return. They can set in motion some badly-needed restructuring into the sport that has wasted away for want of regular regeneration.

Opinion is divided over what should happen next. Two of Gill's most outspoken critics, IHF Vice-President

Narinder Batra and IHF Joint Secretary K. Krishnamurthy cannot agree whether the IOA's control of Indian hockey should last a few months or a few years. Krishnamurthy, also secretary of Karnataka State Hockey Association is for the former and Batra for the latter. The Bangalore man says a swift to elections and a subsequent de-centralisation of power in the IHF is mandatory, Batra believes prolonged

tenures, wide-ranging powers... you get the drift. Words like "stones" and "glass houses" are being decorously avoided these days because the relief at Gill's departure is so great.

But former India goalkeeper Ashish Ballal, a strident opponent of the Gill regime, confesses to feeling "apprehension" over all else. With table-slamming conviction, Ballal says, "Indian hockey is not only about the national team." Krishnamurthy,

an older more seasoned player in this tempestuous game, emphasises that the Gill regime has critically weakened hockey at various levels—competitions, coaching, umpiring, juniors. "Over a period we've not changed at all. We were just not functioning as a body at all."

A player said he didn't hold corruption against the old guard; what he resented the most was the utter stagnation Gill & Co had been happy to preside over for 14 years without any qualms.

To shake off the ennui, Ballal wants the government involved in setting up a professional structure "This is the best opportunity: get paid executives." Hell, he says, get someone from cricket, reeling off names like Dalmiya, Bindra and Modi, "instead

of the same old people from the state associations."

Yet, in their choice of a new-look selection panel the IOA have gone in for the same-ole, same-ole model. Of the five only Dhanraj Pillay, has a first-hand understanding of modern hockey. His other colleagues may offer some wisdom, but the more independent and progressive voices in Indian hockey should not remain silent any more. Fourteen years is a very long time. ■



Gill was sacked by the IOA which ironically comprised many of his fellow travellers

IOA intervention can act like "governor's rule". Except the "governors" in this case i.e. IOA, happen to be Gill's fellow travellers and kindred spirits.

Those who passed judgement on Gill, the long-running federation chief of a badly-managed discipline who had a generously flexible tenure, wide-ranging powers and zero accountability, were themselves long-running federation chiefs of badly-managed disciplines, with generously flexible